

High Desert.

FIELD SPECIFICATION
V3 · JUNE 2026
REDMOND · CENTRAL OREGON

High Desert is community-owned digital civic infrastructure for Central Oregon — a **verified, ad-free** place for a town's shared life online to belong to the town itself. A member-governed nonprofit, owned by no one and impossible to sell — its mission locked into the articles from day one. Redmond first.

A convivial tool that preserves mētis.

Built to extend a community's own know-how, not to replace it.

THE COMMITMENTS — NON-NEGOTIABLE

01 No ads. Ever.

No attention sold, no feed tuned for engagement.

02 Verified residents only.

Participation is gated by residency, not invitation.

03 Member-owned data.

Yours to export, yours to take, yours to delete.

04 Tenure-weighted democracy.

Secret ballot, weighted 1–3× by time in community. 15% quorum. Every decision reversible.

05 Flat ≈\$2 / month.

One flat price for verified residents, never scope-gated. No price rise without a member vote.

06 Surplus to the commons.

Donations and surplus dues flow to local charities, chosen by member vote.

07 Time & proximity, never popularity.

Nothing is ranked, trending, or boosted.

08 Moderation with due process.

Reasoned, appealable, separated — nothing vanishes silently.

STATUS Built — core platform complete and version-controlled, 35 Redmond neighborhoods seeded. A 60-day closed beta with the ~50-member founding cohort precedes a public Redmond launch in late 2026.

BUILT Verified membership (multi-path, human-reviewed) · neighborhood events & RSVPs · tenure-weighted governance with secret ballots · moderation with appeals · member-owned, exportable data.

A member-governed Oregon nonprofit from day one — no owner, no shares, nothing to sell. The no-advertising and member-data commitments are written into the articles as limits on the corporation's own power, with a dissolution clause routing any assets to aligned Central Oregon charities; 501(c)(3) recognition is pursued from the start and is retroactive to formation. The founder's place is a job, not ownership — a salaried, contracted Founding Executive Director, with a board seat that converts to a permanent non-voting advisory seat and a founder-protection period that sunsets into full member governance. Pay is staged and public, capped below the founder's academic salary; the foundational commitments change only by a 75% member supermajority with a 30-day deliberation.

SCOPE

Launches in Redmond, in partnership with Redmond Compass. Compass owns public discovery; High Desert owns verified-resident participation. Designed for six Central Oregon towns under a hard cap of twelve — small enough to stay real.



GROUNDED IN

A long tradition of thinking about commons, tools, and power. **Ostrom** on governing the commons · **Doctorow** on resisting platform decay · **Scott** on legibility & mētis · **Meadows** on systems · **Hirschman** on voice & exit · **Baradaran** on ownership as destiny — with a tool-design layer from Illich, Polanyi, Schön, Norman & Alexander.

OPEN BY DESIGN

CODE	AGPL-3.0-or-later — the SaaS loophole closed, so it can be replicated without being captured.
DOCS	CC BY-SA 4.0 — the design canon is free to study, adapt, and share.
REPLICATION	Built to be forked and stood up by other communities. Run the code, not the name — “High Desert” is reserved.
STACK	Supabase · Next.js · Tailwind.